

RESEARCH BRIEF

What's actually costing SMEs the most time?

Findings so far, updated as the research progresses. August 2026.

Purpose of this research

Most advice about “digital transformation” is written for enterprises with dedicated IT teams and large budgets. This research is focused specifically on UK small and midsize businesses (SMEs), building an honest, practical picture of where custom technology is worth the investment and where it isn't.

What we're finding so far

Across the SMEs we talk to, the same pattern keeps showing up: work that should take minutes stretches into hours because it still runs through phone calls, spreadsheets and manual re-entry between systems that don't talk to each other.

That matches the UK data too. A July 2026 survey of 1,000 UK micro, small and medium-sized business owners, run by American Express with Small Business Saturday UK, found they spend an average of **11 hours a week** on admin and finance-related tasks (around six working days a month), more than twice what they spend on sales and business development (3.6 days a month). And **54%** said paperwork gets in the way of running their business.

Source: Amex SME Business Barometer, with Small Business Saturday UK, July 2026.

retailtimes.co.uk/amex-sme-barometer-small-business-owners-spend-nearly-twice-the-time-on-admin-than-growing-their-business

A similar pattern shows up elsewhere too. In the US, a 2024 survey of 630 small business owners and executives found manual data entry and reconciling information across different apps eats an average of 25 hours a week, with 91% saying it undermines their productivity.

Source: Intuit QuickBooks Business Solutions Survey, August 2024. erp.intuit.com/blog/research/business-solutions-survey-2024

Where the time actually goes, industry by industry

Reliable, industry-specific research at this level of detail is scarce. A lot of what circulates online turns out to be marketing content citing surveys that don't actually exist. What follows is an honest mix of the data above and the patterns we consistently see scoping projects in each industry, not a formal, industry-by-industry study.

Home Services

Scheduling and dispatch are still coordinated by phone for a lot of independent trades businesses: a technician's day gets built and rebuilt over calls and texts instead of a shared board. Call volume isn't slowing down either. Almost a third of privately rented homes in England (32%) were built before 1919 and older housing stock generally means more repairs, not fewer, according to the government's 2024 English Housing Survey.

Retail

For small multi-location retailers, the recurring time sink is inventory reconciliation: keeping stock counts consistent between a point-of-sale system and an online store when the two aren't connected usually means

someone manually checking and adjusting numbers at the end of each day, or discovering the mismatch only after a customer has already bought something that wasn't actually in stock.

Professional Services

Client onboarding at firms like accounting practices and consultancies is still commonly run through email: documents requested one at a time, chased individually and tracked in an inbox rather than a shared checklist. The bottleneck usually isn't any single document. It's the back-and-forth needed to collect all of them.

Real Estate

Maintenance requests for rental properties typically arrive through a mix of phone calls, texts and emails, with no single record of what was reported, assigned, or resolved. That makes a simple question hard to answer: how many requests are open right now and how long has each one been waiting?

Hospitality

Ordering between restaurants and their suppliers still runs largely on phone calls: a kitchen calls in an order, a supplier confirms it verbally and neither side has a shared, live record of what was actually agreed. When an order is wrong or late, resolving it means another phone call rather than simply checking its status.

Logistics

For smaller logistics and delivery operations, shipment status often lives in whichever system last touched it: a driver's text, a dispatcher's spreadsheet, a customer's email. Reliably knowing where a shipment actually is usually means checking several places by hand rather than one shared source of truth.

A note on methodology

This isn't a formal academic study. It combines cited third-party research (linked above wherever we use it) with patterns we consistently see when scoping projects for SMEs in these industries. We're upfront about which is which and we'll add more primary research as we gather it. This brief is updated as the research progresses. Check techwithtop.co.uk/research for the current version.

info@techwithtop.co.uk